

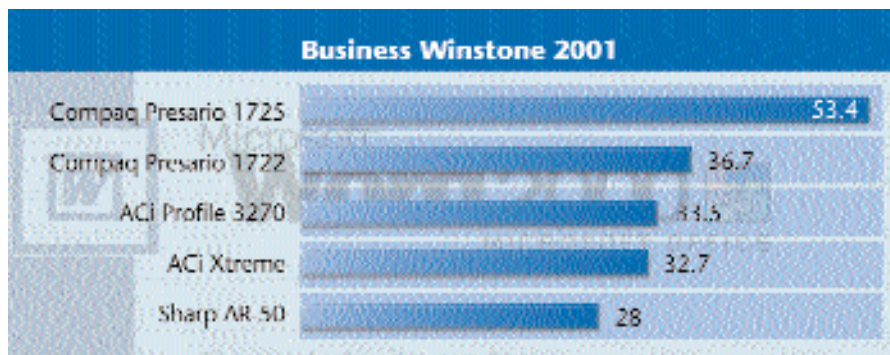
careful while using them. However, you will always know a good LCD screen when you see one. The screen size available today is as high as 15.1-inch and the resolution supported due to a good integrated graphics sub-system can go as high as 1600x1200 wide screen.

Since looks matter more, the competition in this space is fiercer. Every inch is important, and resolutions and sizes of screens have become critical factors in buying decisions.

In terms of pure size, there was no question as to who the winner was: The ACi Xtreme. It showed how much 'extreme' can stretch with a uniquely fitted 15.1-inch SXGA TFT screen supporting a maximum resolution of 1400x1050.

The rest of the notebooks were using standard 14.1 Active Matrix XGA TFT screens with support for a resolution of 1400x1050 and 16 million colors. The build quality of the Compaq and the ACi screens was top-notch. Sharp screens had impressive clarity, especially the Muramasu PC UM10, which had a 12.1-inch TFT screen with excellent sharpness and colour rendition. None of the laptops had any artifacting on the screens or, more notably, bad pixels.

The responsiveness of the TFT screens was also checked for. This was done while running *Quake III*. There was only a slight motion blur on most screens when there was excessive movement in the game. This made watching DVDs or VCDs an enjoyable experience. Overall, the Sharp AR-50 was the winner in terms of screen clarity and sharpness.



Accessories and software bundle

Most of the notebooks came pre-installed with the top-of-the-line Windows XP Home edition as the standard operating system. Sharp's notebooks came bundled with Windows Me while the Zenith 21A and the Compaq Armada E-500 came with the dated Windows 98 SE as the OS.

The Presario series came bundled with the most impressive software—Microsoft Windows XP Home Edition, coupled with Microsoft Works 6, Win DVD, and separate CDs of Money 2001, Norton Anti-Virus 2002, Studio DV as well as an impressive CD documentation explaining the entire package in detail. One more thing, the software bundle came along with a special OS crash recovery CD to minimise downtimes.

Sharp AR-50 had software bundled with Adaptec Easy CD Creator, MGI PhotoSuite III SE, TCI Fax Talk, Voquette Media Manager, and McAfee VirusScan.

The Zenith 21A was the barest minimum in these terms. It just had a Windows 98 SE licensed CD and a manual.

Build quality, ergonomics and weight

This is probably the most subjective of all the tests. But a few things here stand out immediately. For example, there was no doubting the supreme build quality of the Presario notebooks. The clamshells of these notebooks were truly professional and aesthetic. From the way you open the notebook to the manner in which the keyboard is laid out—everything about the Presario oozes confidence and flamboyant design. It weighs 2.36 kg, is easy to work with, possesses a superior key layout, and its beveled and softly curved palm rests easy on the wrist. Working with the Presario is made pleasurable with a four-way Internet scroll, instant Internet, and audio and e-mail launch keys. It has a special digital one-touch control for volume control and a full size keyboard with separate cursor control keys. The speakers too are intelligently placed on the front side, unlike some other notebooks where the palm itself rests on the speaker and hinders the audio output.

The Sharp series has focused more on

Laptop Maintenance and Care

Like any other device, laptops too need a fair share of care and maintenance, sometimes a little more than desktop PCs.

Try to keep the computer as clean as possible. Avoid transporting or using it in dusty environments. Use the carrying bag provided or some other clean container when you transport the laptop.

Make sure the computer is turned off before unplugging it. When you disconnect cords, remember to pull them by the plugs and not by the cords themselves. This will prevent damage to the cords, plugs, ports, and jacks.

Use a high-quality electrical surge protector, if possible, when the AC adapter powers your computer. It is also a good idea to

unplug your computer when it is not in use.

How do I clean the display?

Use a soft damp cloth, clean the surface of the screen gently. If there are stubborn dirt stains, do not put more pressure. Instead, use ISO Propyl alcohol to clean the stain. Do not use gritty, rough-textured cloth or paper to clean the screen as this can leave permanent scratches.

How do I dust the keyboard?

Blow hard into the keyboard and then gently turn the laptop upside down. This should get rid of all loose dust and grit that may have accumulated between the keyboard keys. Alternatively, you could also use a vacuum cleaner to blow out any dirt that might deposited on the keyboard.

What about the battery?

A common problem faced by most laptop users is the progressive deterioration in reliability after the first year of service. This loss occurs gradually without the user knowing. Even though the battery may show as fully charged, its capacity to hold that charge diminishes to the extent that it may sometimes hold less than half its original capacity.

Batteries work best if they are completely discharged before recharging, and that goes for all types (though Lithium-Ion needs this less frequently). When you start using your battery for the first time, drain and recharge it entirely at least three or four times.